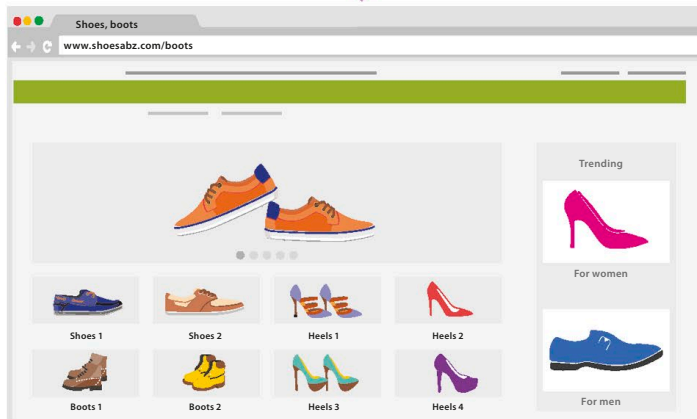


Effective searching

With over a billion websites in existence, finding the right one can be very difficult. For a more focused search, it is useful to think about the words used to search. The words typed into a search engine are called search terms. The more specific a search query is, the more likely it is that the search engine will find the right website.

"shoe", "boots", "footwear",
"fashion", "style", "value"



LINGO

Better searching

Quotation marks (" "): Putting a phrase in quotation marks returns only those pages where that specific phrase appears.

Plus sign (+): A plus symbol between two search terms returns pages where both the terms appear. Searching for "cats + ships" will return pages that mention both cats and ships.

Minus sign (-): A minus symbol between two search terms returns pages where only the first term appears. Searching for "islands - tropical" returns pages about non-tropical islands.

Asterisk (*): An asterisk is a wildcard that can match a variety of words. Putting an asterisk in a phrase searches for that phrase containing any word in place of the asterisk. Searching for "comput*" returns results for computer, computation, computes, and so on.

< Keywords

People creating websites often add keywords to them. Keywords make it easier for search engines to find the website. For instance, a webpage for shoes might add "shoes" and "boots" as keywords to its website.

Comparison websites

These websites undertake multiple related searches to collect the results in an easily comparable format. Instead of looking at several websites and filling in a variety of online forms, users can just use one comparison website. Website owners often allow comparison websites to access their data for a charge. It's also possible for the website to get the data by a systematic process called crawling, where a web robot or crawler gathers information from different websites.

▷ What's the secret?

The exact methods used by search engines to work out which websites to return at the top of search results are kept secret. Getting websites to appear further up the rank of results is now a big business for many Search Engine Optimization (SEO) companies.

